

3.3 Firefox

A lot has been written about Firefox (FF) and over the last few years, it has been the browser to take the fight back to the IE camp with its slogan “Take back the Web”. If you were living in the Himalayas (we’d like to do that someday) for the last few years then you would not have noticed that the browser market has steadily started getting more and more fragmented—particularly in the last two years. With the ‘Spread Firefox’ campaign getting more and more popular around 2005, more users realised that it was able to browse faster than IE, was more Web standard-compliant, and boasted of better security at the time. Add to that tabbed browsing and the ability to add more functionality, and quite a few Web surfers shifted loyalty to FF in droves.

FF is a free and open source browser, which is available for the Windows, Linux, and Mac platform and relies on the support of the Web community to build new features for the browser and test them. The ideology behind the browser, according to its developers, is to deliver the “best possible browsing experience to the widest possible set of people.” The latest version of FF is version three, which is currently in beta. The FF browser allows tabbed browsing, an in-line spell checker, bookmarking and a download manager among other features.

3.3.1 Add-Ons

Like IE and Maxthon, FF also allows users to add functionality to the browser by adding add-ons. Its biggest advantage however lies in the fact that FF has the more number of add-ons than IE and Maxthon combined. As of January 2008, it is estimated to have over three thousand add-ons. In FF, add-ons are divided in three distinctive groups: **Plugins:** These help the browser perform specific tasks—viewing certain graphic formats, playing certain multimedia file types, etc.

Extensions: These are small add-ons that add new functionality; this can range from a simple toolbar button to a completely new feature in the browser.

Themes: These allow you to change the UI of the browser, like in Maxthon.